

Local galaxy group

The majority of galaxies¹ form groups held together by gravity. Some groups are really gargantuan in size, e.g., groups in Virgo and Berenice's Hair constellations feature thousands of galaxies stretched over some 20 million light years. Smaller galaxy groups do exist, an example is our own galaxy – the Milky Way. This group, called Local Group, comprises some 30 galaxies stretched over some 5 million light years. The most famous galaxies of the Local Group are Milky Way, Andromeda, and M33 galaxy in the Triangulum constellation. The groups themselves form less thick groups, called supergroups. The latter are the greatest objects in the Universe, stretched over hundreds of millions of light years. The Local Group is a part of the Local Supergroup, the center of which is located in the group in Virgo constellation.

Facts & figures

Galaxy name	Distance (light years)	Diameter (light years)	Luminance (millions of Suns)	Type
Milky Way	0	100 000	15 000	Spiral
Greater Magellanic Cloud	170 000	30 000	2 000	Irregular Spiral
Lesser Magellanic Cloud	190 000	20 000	500	Irregular
Draco	300 000	3 000	0,1	Elliptical
Carina	300 000	3 000	0,01	Elliptical
Sculptor	300 000	6 000	1	Elliptical
Sextans	300 000	3 000	0,01	Elliptical
Ursa Minor	300 000	2 000	0,1	Elliptical
Fornax	500 000	6 000	12	Elliptical
Leo I	600 000	2 000	0,6	Elliptical
Leo II	600 000	2 000	0,4	Elliptical
NGC 6822	1 800 000	15 000	90	Irregular
WLM	2 000 000	6 000	90	Irregular
Andromeda	2 200 000	150 000	40 000	Spiral
Andromeda I	2 200 000	5 000	1	Elliptical
Andromeda II	2 200 000	5 000	1	Elliptical
Andromeda III	2 200 000	5 000	1	Elliptical
M32	2 200 000	5 000	130	Elliptical
NGC 147	2 200 000	8 000	50	Elliptical
NGC 185	2 200 000	8 000	60	Elliptical
NGC 205	2 200 000	11 000	160	Elliptical
M33	2 400 000	40 000	5 000	Spiral
DDO 210	3 000 000	5 000	2	Irregular
Pisces	3 000 000	2 000	0,6	Irregular
GR 8	4 000 000	1 500	2	Irregular
Sagittarius	4 000 000	4 000	1	Irregular
Pegasus	5 000 000	7 000	20	Irregular
Leo A	5 000 000	7 000	20	Irregular



¹Irregular galaxies

The galaxies that have no regular form are called "irregular". An example is the Lesser Magellanic Cloud. The irregular galaxies are very small, much less than the Milky Way, yet they contain great amounts of gas from which new stars are formed. The Lesser Magellanic Cloud is among the nearest to the Milky Way, it can be seen in the Southern Hemisphere.



Elliptical galaxies

Elliptical galaxies are very few in number in the Local Group, and are only poorly visible. An example is the M87 galaxy from the Virgo Group. It is a big ball made of more than a thousand billion old red stars and a few novas. The stars always move in the same direction in an elliptical galaxy.



Crossed spiral galaxies

NGC1365, part of the Fornax group, is a spiral galaxy with a short "bridge" comprised of older stars. The ends of bridge feature arms. Such spiral is called a bridge. The bridge rotates as if it were a solid body, however, it is made from millions of separate stars. It is possible that the Milky Way is also such a galaxy.